auctioned to private firms. Yet several auctions had to be cancelled due to lack of interest. Senior figures at Petrobras, Brazil's blue-chip investment stock for many decades and the crown jewel of public firms, were deeply implicated in the spreading political corruption scandal, and the firm's shares, normally steady, had dropped 60 percent in value in 2014, negatively affecting its coveted international credit rating. Combined with falling international petroleum prices, some analysts expected losses at Petrobras of as much as $20 billion.[257] Petrobras' expansive capital investment programs were (*de facto*) cancelled. Finance Minister Mantega, the policymaker most responsible for Brazil's notably expansionary response to the global financial crisis of 2008–2009, as well as for its subsequent and less justified continuation, also received the blame for negative growth and worsening public finances in 2013 and 2014, and in January 2015, President Rousseff replaced Mantega with Joaquim Levy, a prominent orthodox and apolitical economist. Levy immediately began to take actions to pare government spending, although resistance from both the government's own party and the Congressional coalition, as well as politically motivated noncooperation from the center-right, which otherwise would have supported his actions, made policy change difficult.[258]

In this context, publicists of the beleaguered president gave maximum publicity to the May 2015 visit of Chinese Premier Li Keqiang, and to Rousseff's announcement of China's promise to invest up to $53 billion, mainly in transportation, power, and other infrastructure.[259] Despite the fanfare, opposition figures and Brazil's press were quite skeptical of how many of the announced projects actually would be built, noting, for example, that a planned Transoceanic Railway connecting Brazil's Atlantic Coast with Pacific Ocean ports in Peru had not even had a serious feasibility study.[260]

Despite the heroic efforts of the government to portray the visit as an equal partnership, as well as a win for Brazil, skepticism of China's motives and general reliability was widespread in the elite media. Many commentators recalled the experience early in President da Silva's first term on the occasion of a similar visit to Brazil by then-Chinese President Hu Jintao in May 2004. At that time, China requested, and received, Brazilian support for China's bid to be awarded "market economy status" at the WTO, which would make it substantially more difficult for Brazilian